



Figure 3: Navigating the music collection

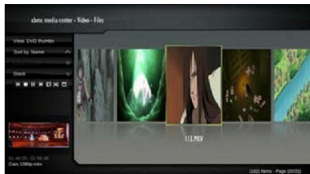


Figure 4: Navigating the video collection

have pre-compiled binaries for XBMC:

1. Ubuntu: <https://launchpad.net/~team-xbmc/+archive/ppa>
2. Mandriva: <http://mib.pianetlinux.org/mib/repository.html>
3. openSUSE: http://en.opensuse.org/Additional_YaST_Package_Repositories#Packman
4. Sabayon: <http://www.sabayonlinux.org/>
5. Dreamlinux: <http://www.dreamlinux.com.br/download.html>

For notes on installation, see the sidebar.

Rock n' roll in eye candy

Post installation, the application launches in windowed mode—only Sabayon opens it in full screen, or 'Party Mode' as I like to call it. Clicking on the maximise button, maximises the window. After pondering over various possible shortcut keys, I finally got the solution—you need to hit the \ (back slash) key for a full-screen media centre view.

The XBMC interface is quite lucid with very well laid out categories. The player menu has been segregated into videos, music, photos, weather, scripts and settings. The first three options will ask you to add media sources while it auto detects any externally attached medium. On the downside, it cannot read Flash drives above 4GB because it still follows USB 1.1 standards, and that too, only FAT-formatted drives. So, if you're in the habit of using EXT3/NTFS formatted Flash drives, you're out of luck.



Figure 5: The bookmark wizard



Figure 6: Image viewer

The player has very unique display options. You can navigate through your collection with small or big icons, and these come with a variety of exquisite effects and some gorgeous cover flow effects. Pretty much everything is available for you to make the most out of your well-managed collection.

The music player is very good, but I find the volume not as loud as it could be. Even cranking the volume to full from the XBMC settings does not have much effect on the overall volume output. However, the beauty of the player is that you can resume doing your work, like goofing around with the player, viewing photographs and inspecting the collection, while a small display of the currently playing track/movie runs at the bottom left of the application.

Moving on to the movies, I tried my Blue-ray, full high-definition content and was blown away with the output. Although the movies play as they do in a normal player, here you can even watch the movie in the main menu while continuing your work, as you can see in Figure 1. And you can bookmark the movie at a particular time interval, which allows you to resume watching it from where you had left it.

The player supports a plethora of audio/video and image formats. It picks up the subtitles correctly, although in some videos I have had to enable them from the settings. The only let down is not being able to play DRM-restricted media files, besides the inability of XBMC to read multi-session discs.